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## Transformation

Forty years after the publication of the *St Louis Blues* (1914) jazz had become, in one form or another, an international musical language. A publicity-conscious American impresario could advertise a plan to recruit an ‘international’ orchestra including players from thirteen European countries, and he might as readily have recruited them from the other continents. However, international jazz remained almost entirely a second-hand version of the American music. The history of the evolution and transformation of jazz, as distinct from the history of its propagation, remains an American subject. Its musical details will be discussed in Chapters 4–6. This chapter merely tries to get the whole business into perspective. This is very much worth doing, for the internal development of jazz has been quite as rapid and startling as its expansion, and even more surprising. The evolution of Western classical music, which is rather rapid and revolutionary by the standards of past history, is measured in centuries. Jazz has passed through equally profound and revolutionary transformations—though on a much more modest scale—in decades. The road from the New Orleans funeral procession to Mr Charles Mingus’s ‘jazz experiments’ is at least as long as that from Monteverdi to Alban Berg.

We may conveniently divide the history of jazz into four main phases: (1) the ‘prehistoric’ from c. 1900 to 1917; (2) the ‘ancient’ from c. 1917 to c. 1929; (3) ‘middle period’ from c. 1929 to the early 1940s; and (4) ‘modern’ from then on; or, in terms of the commercial labels attached to each, ‘ragtime’, ‘jazz’, ‘swing’, and ‘bop’ or ‘cool’.<sup>\*</sup> The historian of the future may detect some subsequent turning-points—for instance the rise of jazz to quasi-art-music status and the irruption of the blues into pop music—but it is wisest to leave these discoveries to those who will be

able to see the 1950s in perspective. 'Prehistoric' and 'ancient' jazz might also be conveniently considered together.

'Ancient' jazz (e.g. in the 'New Orleans', 'Dixieland', 'Chicago', and 'New York' styles) is a music of small improvising bands with rudimentary arrangements, of blues singers and pianists. 'Middle period' jazz is essentially a music of larger commercial bands and the virtuosi they bred; a much more 'composed' and 'arranged' as well as a more technically demanding music. The 'modern' period has fled back into improvisation, and the small group, whether in the form of a deliberate return to 'ancient' jazz (the 'revival' movements) or a deliberate leap forward into a revolutionary *avant-garde* music ('bop'), some of which has increasingly turned into a hybrid between jazz and classical music ('cool'). In the course of this it has dropped a good deal of improvisation for ambitious, sophisticated, if not always successful genres of jazz composition. Socially, ancient jazz was a music for Southerners or first-generation black migrants to the North, which was also adopted or listened to by minorities of whites. 'Middle period' jazz was a music for blacks acclimatized to big city life, and for a mass American white public of youngsters. 'Modern' jazz was and is *avant-garde* music for musicians and a coterie public of white intellectuals and bohemians, though its public has grown, as its original revolutionary sounds became familiar and accepted, much as have the Matisse and Picassos of our century in painting. Revivalist jazz is not a music for black audiences at all, but for white youths and intellectuals. In Europe, but not in America, it has increasingly become a standard type of dance-music for adolescents.

Beneath these fashions, however, one kind of music has continued comparatively unchanged: the quintessential sound of the urban and rural blacks, the blues. Speeded up in the cities, it has provided the 'jumping', shouting noise which is the heartbeat of the black ghetto, whether it emerges from dance halls, bar rooms, or churches. At bottom the public of (unintellectual) city blacks, which is the fundamental audience for jazz, has remained faithful to this rather than to any particular phase of jazz, at any rate since the 1920s. This is why the middle period jazz of rocking and swinging bands like Chick Webb's and Lionel Hampton's, or of 'jumping' saxophone players like Earl Bostic, has perhaps come nearest to permanent popularity in the black quarters than any other.

Perhaps this is also why rock-and-roll, which is remotely based on the 'jump' blues, made greater inroads on the black public than previous fashions in commercial music. The blues, urban and immigrant, has remained the constant background to jazz evolution.

This outline, crude to the point of caricature, is not intended to provide the reader with an account of jazz evolution. It is merely supposed to give some rough orientation, like the maps on airline timetables, which are not to be judged as accurate geographical representations. But even such diagrams must draw attention to important traffic junctions. In the history of jazz there are two. The first marks its change from an old-fashioned folk-music to a hybrid between folk and commercial music, and the growing isolation of the jazz musician from his old public. On the whole the evolution of jazz up to 1941 can be chiefly accounted for in such terms. The second marks a much more deliberate musical break: the revolution which produced 'bop' and 'cool' jazz, but also—neither modernists nor traditionalists will thank me for this observation—the deliberate return to archaism of the 'revivalists'. In some respects this was the product of the tendencies which had dominated earlier jazz evolution, but it also reflected what can only be described as an 'ideological' revolt, in which the 'political' elements were incomparably greater. Let us put it another way. Jazz evolution up to the end of the middle period was the product of unselfconscious popular musicians, playing as such musicians have always played, for an unselfconscious public which wanted to be entertained. (The self-conscious small jazz public appreciated but did not determine jazz evolution.) Jazz evolution since 1941 or thereabouts (or, to be more accurate, since 1938–42) has also been the product of self-conscious musicians playing for a self-conscious public; i.e. it has had far greater affinities with modern minority culture. Modern jazz has not been played only for fun, for money, or for technical expertise: it has also been played as a manifesto—whether of revolt against capitalism or commercial culture, or of black equality, or of something else. The line between the two periods is naturally not very clear. Just as there are ancestors of the 'modern' approach before the end of the thirties, so a great deal of jazz has continued to move along the old tracks since; but this does not disturb the broad validity of the generalization. In terms of music, the

break between the two periods is very sharp indeed. Jazz evolution until the end of the thirties proceeded in something like a single general direction: each successive 'style' tended to derive from its immediate predecessors, adding to and modifying them. The modern evolution begins with a deliberate about-turn. The 'revivalists' (a movement of the public rather than the musicians) deliberately rejected the existing jazz for a kind of music which had been virtually dead for at least a decade. The 'boppers' (a movement of the musicians rather than the public) deliberately rejected the existing jazz for a music which, by existing standards, would sound dissonant, anarchic, and technically so difficult to play as to be almost beyond the reach of more than a small *avant-garde*. They also rejected (as we shall see in the chapter on the jazz musician) most of the social conventions of the older jazz musicians.

The *first* crucial change was in the public for jazz. There is all the difference in the world between music played for a home or an away audience. For the New Orleans man the *Canal Street Blues* was about an identifiable street, the *2:19 Blues* about an identifiable train. For the country minstrel who sings

*I'm goin' to Houston, Texas, 'Lightning' Hopkins is the man I want  
to see,  
Oh, Houston, Texas, 'Lightning' Hopkins is the man I want to see  
Well now, if you can't stand my jivin', I'm gonna give you the third  
degree<sup>1</sup>*

his blues has a specific purpose: in this instance the challenge of one guitar-picker (Sam 'Lightning' Hopkins) by another (Brownie McGhee). For an outside audience it is just a blues, whose title and text—and hence whose music—mean as little as the records named after phrases of esoteric Harlem slang mean to Blackburn adolescents. Folk-art inevitably loses much of its concreteness as soon as it leaves communities which recognize its detailed allusions and references. As jazz became the general idiom of music for the black city immigrants, it inevitably lost some of its roots.

This loss was temporarily camouflaged by the unlimited demand for nostalgia which uprooted communities produce, and which made homesickness into an endemic disease of nineteenth- and early twentieth-century Europe. It also made the song recalling the (idealized) past into the most typical product of nineteenth-century Tin Pan Alley, in which Irish mothers and Yiddisher mommas abounded, and home was on the range, where never is heard a discouraging word. Black migrants were fortunately immune from the temptation to idealize either good old Dixie or their childhoods, but the mass migration to the North and into the cities unquestionably multiplied the demand for 'music from down home.' On its most modest levels this produced what has been called the 'urban blues singers' circuits', the bar rooms and 'rent parties' <sup>±</sup> in Harlem or on the Chicago Black Belt, served by the guitar-pickers and itinerant piano players. At a higher level it produced the mass public for the classic blues singers in the big urban vaudeville theatres, and the demand for New Orleans jazz in cities like Chicago. Commercially it produced the large crop of blues and other jazz pieces named after specific places in the South: St Louis, Beale Street, Perdido Street, Memphis, Dallas, Nashville Woman's Blues, Milenberg Joys, and so on. However, the demand for 'the old music' was strictly limited, if only by the vast contempt of urbanized and Northern blacks for rural and Southern ones. City ways, emancipation, and progress were what they wanted, except perhaps in religion. The rapid decline and fall of the great classic blues singers after 1927 illustrates the tenuousness of their loyalty to the old music. It is no accident that the black public has remained totally immune to the revival of traditional jazz and blues.

The *second* crucial change, which almost followed from the first, was the retreat of traditional music before commercial pop music; or more precisely, the increasing encroachment of pop music on jazz. Once out of its traditional social setting, nothing is less resistant than folk-art, for its artists and public practise it not because they have a strong preference for it, but because it is the only art they know. The new public, contemptuous of its miserable past, wanted new entertainment. The musician wanted to earn money. The established entertainment industry of the modern city provided the money and the standards. Why should the musicians object?

Jazz became heavily and progressively infiltrated with ‘pop’ elements. But it did not become pop music. It remained, in important respects, the dominant partner in the marriage with commercialism, because the jazz musician, while welcoming commercialization also, and inevitably, rejected it as boring and automatic, an activity unfit for the creative artist: ‘Mickey Mouse music’, as the hot players called it in the thirties. Much of the evolution of jazz was therefore determined by this mixed attraction and repulsion of the pops.

Both transformed the jazz orchestra. As we have seen, jazz history from the early 1920s on is mostly that of progress towards the large ‘swing’ band; but the big band with its characteristic instrumentation and ‘arrangements’ is merely the result of the attempt to make jazz more like successful commercial entertainment. Jazz, however, transformed the big band which, in pop music, is merely a collection of musical zombies who do not greatly mind how they play. The big band of jazz musicians, who play well only when there is a creative spark about, required considerable musical innovation before it would work well. Some of the most important musical developments in jazz can be traced back to this need to adapt the big band to it; notably the constant and progressive improvement and sophistication of rhythm, on which the entire structure of jazz must always rest. The progress from the older beat to the supple ‘swing’ of the middle-period rhythm sections is an example.

Again, commercialization transformed the jazz repertoire, which—for obvious reasons—rested increasingly on the current pop song, the ‘ballad’. The history of jazz since 1917 might well be written as that of its attempts to come to terms with the song-hit. The ballad formed no serious part of the repertoire of New Orleans or the old blues; any pop songs used were assimilated to the traditional marches, stomps, blues, etc., in the manner habitual among folk-artists. Bessie Smith’s well-known version of *Alexander’s Ragtime Band* is a good example.<sup>±</sup> At the other extreme, the repertoire of modern jazz is almost exclusively based on the ballad, the fundamental experiments of the boppers being simply transformed song-hits like *How High the Moon*, or *All the Things You Are*. Even when playing the blues, a modern trumpeter like Miles Davis thinks automatically in terms of the way in which a ballad is played,

rather than in terms of a traditional blues piece.<sup>2</sup> But jazz transformed the ballad out of all recognition. When playing or singing it 'straight', it either deliberately mocked it, as in Fats Waller's satirical piano-songs, or it took it at its word, turning it into a touching or profound and perfectly sincere expression of emotion, as in the songs and trumpet solos of Louis Armstrong and the songs of the great women jazz singers like Billie Holiday and Ella Fitzgerald. When using it as the basis for jazz improvisation, it progressively elaborated it, until in modern jazz the actual theme of the song-hit, as originally written, may not even appear at all. In both cases it selected. Each jazz 'style' chose from among the mass of current hits a certain number of 'standards', pieces which practice had shown to be particularly suited for jazz elaboration, and these became the nucleus of its permanent repertoire. Thus, out of the eighty-odd pop tunes published in 1928 and listed in Spaeth's *History of American Popular Music*, only four have become anything like jazz 'standards': *I Can't Give You Anything but Love*, *Diga-diga-doo* (both written for the black show 'Blackbirds of 1928'), *Sweet Sue*, and *Nagasaki*.

Inevitably, however, commercialized music repelled and bored the jazz player, and the large band imposed awkward impersonal discipline on him. The history of Duke Ellington's band, surely the least low-brow of successful jazz orchestras, is one of progressive disillusion and discontent among the players almost from the moment in which the small, freely blowing group of musicians turned into the organized and 'arranged' band: 'no longer', as its historian says, 'was playing the exultant personal expression it had once been.'<sup>8</sup> If this was the case in fairly uncompromising jazz bands, it was naturally even more so in those which deliberately went out to please the crowds at all costs, not to mention the 'sweet' and 'corny' bands in which many white jazz musicians had to earn their living.

The *third* crucial development in jazz is the consequence of this revulsion. The jazzmen learned to live in two musical worlds: the one in which they earned their living, and the one after hours in which they played to please themselves—the world of the 'jam session'. Except for those who, like many early white jazz players before 1935, worked in purely commercial bands, the two worlds were not as sharply distinct as

one might think. The ‘jam session’ was often regarded merely as the experimental laboratory in which ideas later to be used in public were tried and elaborated. Moreover, all jazz players still dreamed, and continue to dream, of small ‘combos’ in which they could both play as they please and please the public; or at any rate earn their living and play for a public which does not get in the way too much. The history of jazz is littered with such small groups, on temporary engagements in some club, but always turning into ‘jam sessions’ as other musicians drop by to ‘sit in’; or got together for the recording studio. But the sharp distinction between playing for musicians and playing for the public was established; and so, increasingly, was the distinction between playing ‘commercial’ and playing for interest:

‘Well, Dizzy and Milt Hinton’, says Danny Barker the guitarist, ‘between those two-and-a-half-hour shows at the Cotton Club ... would retire to the roof. Dizzy would blow his new ideas in progressions, and he and Hinton would experiment on different ideas and melodic patterns, and they would suggest that I come up and join them. But after that two-and-a-half-hour show, sometimes I’d go up and sometimes I wouldn’t. Because what they were doing called for a lot of mental concentration on harmonies. It was very interesting, but I couldn’t see going up there and wasting energies on something not commercial.’<sup>3</sup>

Jazz, originally an urban folk-music, therefore simultaneously developed towards commercial pop music, and towards a special kind of music for musicians, i.e. the embryo of art music. The 1920s and 1930s in jazz evolution were dominated by the drift towards commercialism (though, as we have seen, this produced not pop music, but an independent music based increasingly on pop materials). The 1940s and 1950s have been equally dominated by the reaction towards musicians’ music—the *avant-garde* semi-art music of the ‘boppers’ and ‘cool’ players, much of it designed to be incomprehensible to the non-expert. But, in spite of considerable efforts, it has not so far produced art-music in the orthodox sense either, but an independent music increasingly infiltrated by elements of classical music. Suspended somewhere



between its folk-music origins and the pop and art-music towards which it is simultaneously urged, jazz remains hard to classify.

This difficulty—and with it most of the merits of jazz—arises from the fact that, at bottom, it had never ceased to be folk-music. It has merely retired from the wider community of the traditional folk-public and folk-artist into the narrower but real and vivid community of the professional craftsman-musician. Within this community the music has gone on living the same sort of life as in folk-music; fluctuating and shifting, personal, traditional, propagated by word of mouth and apprenticeship, created as it is played, reflecting all facets of the players' lives. Its terms of reference were more restricted. The titles of jazz records from the middle twenties on often reflect esoteric jokes and allusions, sometimes expressed in the Harlem slang of the 'hipster', which is deliberately designed to baffle the outsider. The cryptic titles of Ellington's numbers in the late thirties are good examples: *Hip Chic*, *Old King Dooji*, *Portrait of the Lion* (Willie, 'The Lion', Smith, a well-known New York pianist), *Little Posey* (nickname of one of Ellington's trumpeters), *Weely* (nickname of his arranger), *Cotton Tail*, etc. On the other hand, its evolution was vastly speeded up, for the life of the jazz player is, like that of the chess player, who resembles him in his exclusive devotion to his art, nothing but a succession of matches and tournaments, of constant comparisons of achievement, a mixture of cooperation and competition. The 'jam session', in which players get together after hours for their own pleasure, is both collective experiment and contest. Jo Jones the drummer, writing of Kansas City, recreates one aspect of it:

Now those were pretty tough times and yet the guys did take the time to study, and when they had found something new they would bring it to the session and they would pass it round to the other musicians, no matter what instrument they played. So they would try that particular riff or that particular conception at a session and perfect it. The idea of a jam session then wasn't who could play better than somebody else—is was a matter of contributing something and experimentation. Jam sessions were our fun, our outlet.<sup>4</sup>

But Mary Lou Williams the pianist, writing about the same town at the same time, also recreates the other, competitive aspect of the session—the ‘cutting’, or trying to outplay someone else:

The word went round that Hawkins [the best tenor sax player of the period, EJH] was in the Cherry Blossom, and within about half an hour there were Lester Young, Ben Webster, Herschel Evans, Herman Walder, and one or two unknown tenors piling into the club to blow.

Bean (Hawkins’s nickname) didn’t know the Kaycee tenor men were so terrific, and he couldn’t get himself together, though he played all morning. I happened to be nodding that night, and around 4 a.m. I awoke to hear someone pecking on my screen.

I opened the window on Ben Webster. He was saying ‘Get up pussy-cat, we’re jammin’ and all the pianists are tired out now. Hawkins has got his shirt off and is still blowing. You got to come down.’<sup>5</sup>

The community of jazz players existed—and exists—in every city in which jazz is played, like the old communities of craftsmen; and as the old travelling journeymen would automatically visit the ‘house of call’ in each town, to meet colleagues and pick up news and jobs, so the new or touring musician in every town from Los Angeles to London and Paris knows where to drop in, how to find those who can tell him who’s in town, what music is on, and where a man can sit in with a band. For jazz is collective music, practised and discussed only in common. The peculiar atmosphere of these half anchored, half freely floating communities of players, who know the pattern of each others’ lives, which is not that of the ‘squares’ or outsiders, whether musical or non-musical, made jazz. It has to be experienced, if only from the side lines. The outsider will not really grasp it until he has seen an out-of-town, hard-bitten professional, with twenty years of touring behind him, put a good-looking chorus girl whom he has picked up for the night on some remote couch, while he spends two hours listening to and discussing jazz records with a few local musicians and collectors. And not even his own records: simply good and interesting records from which a musician can

learn something. Perhaps a description by a player can give a slight impression of this milieu:<sup>6</sup>

On Sunday afternoons, in the early forties, some of the guys would get together at my house ... we'd have a little session listening to records. We'd listen to a lot of Hawk's records. He was making some in Europe that we'd get. And we'd play things of our own.... Then on Sunday nights we'd go to Lewisohn Stadium when the symphonic session was on. 'We're going to church,' we'd say.

Then later that night we'd go to the Savoy to hear Chick Webb. That was a band that really swung. Then after the Savoy we'd go to Puss Johnson's, an after-hours spot, 130th and St Nicholas, I think. Everybody would come in there. All the guys from the bands downtown. I remember one particular session. Ben Webster and Pres (Lester Young) were there and everybody knew about it....

As for that session with Ben and Lester, there never could be a decision. The house was divided. Most of those there were musicians. There were very, very few outsiders except some real jazz fans. They used to sell lots of chicken and whisky at those sessions.

This particular place was especially for Sunday nights, that was the off-night around New York at about that time. It would start about three in the morning and last to about 9 or 10 a.m. It was always bright daylight when we came out. It just blinded you.

Naturally the music played in this community of craftsmen was not folk-music in any traditional sense. But it grew out of the old folk-music, because that was the mould in which the musicians, their techniques, and their entire idiom had been formed, and above all because the artists remained at all times creator-players and never became mere executants. The craft-pride of the players added to this the powerful elements of competition, experimentation, and the constant striving to master increasingly difficult technical problems. (In doing so the players were untrammelled by conventional ideas as to what the capacities of instruments were.) To play a trumpet with the flowing ease of the

saxophone, a trombone with the glitter and speed of a trumpet, to make the drums 'play tunes' as well as indicate the rhythm: such achievements would test the expert, and perhaps enable the good player to keep ahead of the copyist. 'We're going to play something that they can't steal because they can't play it' is the refrain which runs through all the discussions of the revolutionary 'boppers'. And as each phase of the musicians' 'private' music became in turn commercially successful—a thing half-welcomed, half-deplored by then—the incentive to push still farther ahead grew.

That is why the latter half of the thirties was so crucial a point in jazz evolution. Until 1935 jazz itself had scarcely been commercial. The broad white public demanded the hybrid jazz-coloured pop music, the 'true' jazz fans were not yet numerous enough to make a market, the blacks were too poor to make a worth-while one. 'Ancient' jazz had dropped out of sight. 'Middle-period' jazz lived a submerged life anyway, flourishing best in the modest black ghettos like Harlem and Kansas City where nobody minded what was played so long as it 'jumped', and in the joints and night-spots where nobody minded what was played either so long as the musicians went on playing. Now black big-band jazz turned out to be box office, though more for its lesser white practitioners (Goodman, Shaw, Dorsey, Glenn Miller) than for its genuine stars—the Ellington, Basie, Lunceford, and Chick Webb bands. The specialized jazz-lovers themselves became a commercial public, demanding the impossible, to hear the spontaneous, unplanned jazz of the jam session played to order on the concert platform. Commercialization bit deeper and deeper into the 'private' sector of the jazz world. And so both players and public began the unending search for the genuine unspoiled jazz that would be theirs alone; the former by advancing into the technically revolutionary territory of 'bop', the latter by retreating farther and farther towards the remote fastnesses of the Mississippi Delta. Alas for such hopes! As soon as the commercial value of 'true' jazz was recognized, the pop men fell over themselves to adopt any innovation almost as soon as it was made. Within a few years of the end of the war every commercial big band worth its name played 'bop' arrangements, and the boppers were driven yet farther forward towards the Bartóks and Milhauds who, heaven knows, have never yet produced a hit record,

while the ‘revivalists’ retreated from the Armstrong of 1925 to the Oliver of 1922, from Oliver to Bunk Johnson’s Eagle Band of 1913, and thence to the putative sound of Buddy Bolden. But the hot breath of the box-office was on their necks. Not that the professional players regretted it: they merely regretted the inevitable limitations on their inventions, experimenting, and freedom which it imposed: for instance the tyranny of the ‘request number’ which forced them to repeat *ad nauseam* a limited repertoire of ‘standards’.

From 1935 to the present the race has gone on, and the end is not in sight, though the pursuers have slightly changed in character. For whereas in the hey-day of swing they were mainly the uninstructed ‘square’ audiences, the running has been increasingly made by the growing mass of ‘true’ jazz-lovers, whose very weight tends to strangle the music they wish to embrace.

It is easy to understand why the jazz of the early 1940s tended to take the form of manifestos against commercialism, or against the public, or against the excessively esoteric activities of the musicians: against one aspect or another of the unhealthy situation into which the music had, inevitably, drifted. However, there is more to the jazz revolution than this. From the point of view of the public—the specialized white jazz public—the ‘revival’ was the first large-scale revolt within the framework of popular music, against art as mass production. There is historic justice in the fact that the very heart of ‘Mickey Mouse’ music in its most literal meaning, the Walt Disney Studio, illustrates the revolt of the individual. One of the most characteristic revivalist bands, the ‘Firehouse Five Plus Two’, overflowing with collective improvisation and the musical simple life, was composed of technicians, writers, and animators of that establishment. (Another aspect of this nostalgia for the age before mass production also found a characteristic early outlet among these Californian intellectuals: the hankering after machines with rough corners. A leading member of the band was also a leading light in the ‘Horseless Carriage Club’—the American equivalent of the vintage car craze—and the band was actually named in honour of the 1914 fire engine the band bought and with which it played about.) Nor was this revolt against modern capitalism and its works confined to a few intellectuals. It is fair to claim that the revival became a mass movement

among the West-European young on its anti-commercial as much as on its musical appeal. It was self-made music, or at least music made in the image of the amateur. Its bands—in Britain at least—resisted professionalization for the best part of ten years. Moreover, in Britain and Australia, to a very marked extent, they had and maintained links with the political left. World youth festivals, anti-nuclear marches, May Day demonstrations, or other expressions of hostility to the social *status quo* have rarely lacked their quota of imitation New Orleans jazz players, blues and folksingers, or ‘skiffers’.<sup>¶</sup>

The modern revolution—‘bebop’—which took shape in New York in 1940–2, was a musician’s revolt, not a movement of the public. Indeed, it was a revolt directed against the public as well as against the submergence of the player in standardized floods of commercial noise. But it was also a much more profound and ill-defined manifesto in favour of black equality. The inventors of this revolutionary music were without exception young black players at most in their early twenties, mostly still unknown: John Birks (‘Dizzy’) Gillespie, the trumpeter; Charlie (‘Bird’) Parker, the saxophonist; Thelonious Monk, the pianist; Kenny Clarke and Art Blakey, drummers; Charlie Christian, guitar (the only one who had made a name for himself); Bud Powell (piano); Milt Jackson (vibraharp); Tadd Dameron (arranger); Max Roach (drums); Kinny Dorham (trumpet), and the rest. The nature of their attitude is described more fully in the next chapter and the chapter on the Jazz Musician. What follows is only a brief general survey sufficient to place the jazz revolution into its general setting.

The musical revolutionism of the early 1940s is inconceivable without the political upheavals of the 1930s, which gave American blacks increased confidence, while at the same time bringing them closer to the apparently insurmountable barriers which stood between them and equality. The bebop revolution was political as much as musical. The savage hostility to ‘Uncle Tom’ musicians, which for the first time split the community of jazz players into bitterly feuding sections, the passionate insistence on inventing a music so difficult that ‘they’—the whites who always cash in on black achievement—will ‘not be able to steal it’, even the personal peculiarities of the new players, cannot be

explained in musical terms alone. They stood for a certain attitude of the black artist and intellectual in his own world and that of the whites, whose slang name, *ofays*—from the pig latin for ‘foe’—sufficiently indicates the tension between the races. Theirs would be a music as good as the whites’, even in terms of art-music, but based on black foundations. But they also expressed the resentment and insecurity of blacks who had tried the old recipe for equality—emigration to the northern cities—and who found that the farther it took them from the world of Uncle Tom, the farther off did the world look in which there would be neither whites nor blacks but only American citizens. Moreover, they were isolated even within the black world. They had raised themselves by their talents and achievements above the level of the ordinary labourers from whom they had sprung, or they hoped to do so as artists and intellectuals: but they found themselves shut out not only from the white world but even by the black middle class, that puny body of white-collar and professional workers which hid its consciousness of impotence behind the attempt to construct a feeble caricature of white petty-bourgeois respectability.<sup>7</sup> It is small wonder that their social behaviour was anarchic and bohemian, their music a multiple gesture of defiance.

Oddly enough—thanks mainly to the whites, for the black middle class failed to recognize them<sup>8</sup>—the achievements of the jazz revolutionaries were speedily recognized. White commercial men, ever on the watch for the cash value of novelty, turned ‘bop’ into a slogan. Young white intellectuals and bohemians, recognizing a malaise and unspecified rebelliousness akin to their own, made modern jazz into the music of the ‘beat generation’, the American equivalent of the Continental existentialists. Musical schools and institutions and universities, softened up by the propaganda of the 1930s, were prepared to recognize an important addition to native American culture even when it came from an unexpected and ‘unrespectable’ source. The American Government itself, aware of the propagandist value of jazz as a cultural export, has sent Dizzy Gillespie abroad as a cultural ambassador just like—indeed earlier than—Louis Armstrong. From 1949–50 on, modern jazz has been no more an art of outlaws than cubism in the 1930s. Perhaps the

shift from the 'bebop' to the 'cool' styles of modern jazz about this period reflects this greater acceptance. It certainly helped to make the 'cool' period since 1949 one in which jazz has made more persistent and massive efforts than ever before to fuse with orthodox art music, though the artistic results of this hybridization were generally mediocre, in terms of the achievements of art-music. It also, paradoxically, helped to turn modern jazz, whose founders were without exception black players of plebeian origin, into a music favoured particularly by a host of young white players, notably in California (hence the name 'West Coast School'). However, in the later fifties 'cool' jazz was in turn replaced by a yet more consciously musico-Nationalist revolt of the black players, who favoured a return to the blues, blew 'hot' (or 'hard' as the phrase went), advertised their connexions with gospel-song, and sometimes chose themes reflecting their hankering for Africanism.

When the chronicler of jazz reaches this point the question 'What next?' automatically raises its head. I do not propose to answer it. Prophecy is not the business of this book, and the prophetic record of jazz critics, though no worse than that of, say, academic economists, is too poor to encourage speculation. The evolution of jazz has constantly snatched the victory of fine achievement out of the disasters of commercialization, and today perhaps out of academic etiolation. It has also left its victims; but that is only natural in an art which is by definition 'impure', i.e. which operates in a musical environment subject to permanent and increasing contamination. Jazz critics have expressed their fear and disquiet at these dangers by the invariable statement that 'jazz is in a state of crisis'. Virtually every critical discussion ends on this note of potential doom, even that of M. Hodeir, the standard-bearer of modernism.<sup>9</sup> And so it is, inevitably. Developing as it does through a series of contradictions, actions, and reactions, jazz must be in constant crisis. It is quite possible that one of these crises will see jazz evolution either finally merging with commercial evolution or with the evolution of American art-music. It is more than probable that whatever jazz is played in future will be unpalatable to many critics on musical or social grounds. However, at present there is no reason to believe that the history of jazz is finished.



Even if it were—i.e. if the evolutionary progress of jazz as we have known it should end—it would not mean the end of the music. So long as men and women still sing the blues in Chicago bar rooms, so long as sax players and trumpeters still like to get together over some whisky and chicken sandwiches to jam for their own pleasure, so long as craftsmen and artists in music resist the pressures to turn them into mere executants of someone else's product, some jazz will be played. It may be played in styles which have ceased to develop, but that does not make it less genuine. Jazz as an idiom and a way of playing is too well established to disappear from the scene for a long time and the world is large. It may turn out to be as indestructible as the Wild West, which haunts the imagination of the world long after it has ceased to exist in its own country.

## Notes

[1.](#) Y. Bruynoghe, Blues Today in *Just Jazz* (ed. S. Traill, G. Lascelles, London 1957), 175.

[2.](#) Cf. his interview in *Melody Maker*, 22 February 1958.

[3.](#) N. Shapiro and N. Hentoff, *Hear Me Talkin' to Ya* (London 1955), 306.

[4.](#) *Hear Me ...*, 264–5.

[5.](#) *Ibid.*, 264.

[6.](#) *Ibid.*, 300. The date is wrong. The period must be in the late thirties, for Webb died in 1939, and Hawkins returned from Europe the same year.

[7.](#) Franklin Frazier, *Black Bourgeoisie*, is the best discussion of this sad subject.

[8.](#) Cf. Margaret Just Butcher, *The Negro in American Culture* (Mentor Books 1957), which has got around to Armstrong, Ellington, Bessie Smith, etc., but is apparently unaware of Gillespie and Parker.

[9.](#) A. Hodeir, *Jazz, Its Evolution and Essence* (London 1956), 267.

[\\*](#) I do not propose to argue with the experts who would prefer to date or sub-divide these periods a little differently or who wish to call them by different names.

[†](#) A rent party was technically organized by tenants who could not pay their rent, hired a piano-player, laid in some liquor and pigs' feet, and charged admission to friends and neighbors, hoping to make enough profit out of the affair. The classic description is by Bessie Smith in *Gimme a Pigfoot*.

[‡](#) It has happened that a former pop song, thus assimilated, has eventually —via the later popularity of blues singers—made its way back into the hit parade. This is the case of *Goodnight, Irene*, a song of 1892 vintage, taken into the stock of the folk-minstrel Leadbelly, and rediscovered through him in the 1940s.

[§](#) Barry Ulanov, in *Duke Ellington*, pp. 108–9, describes the sag in the band's morale very clearly.

¶ Since this is a subject which rouses prickly feelings I might as well point out in so many words that I know nothing of the ideological or political views of American revivalists in general and the Firehouse Five in particular, and am *not* implying that they ever had left-wing sympathies.